

Data-Driven Research Questions in the Humanities

Documenting as a Systemic Practice

Open Research in the Digital Humanities

Dr Nadezhda Povroznik

Research Associate, Humanities Data Science and Methodology (HDSM)
Institute of History, Technical University of Darmstadt

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From Disciplinary Interest to Data-Driven Research

Humanities research often begins with a disciplinary interest. A research question can emerge from it, but a suitable dataset does not necessarily exist. There are three main paths:

Path 1

Find or create data that can address the original question — locating sources, collecting material, designing categories, and building a dataset.

Path 2

Reuse an existing dataset and formulate a question based on the available evidence.

Path 3

Combine the two: begin with an existing dataset, identify its limitations, add carefully documented external material, and develop a more precise question.

Work on humanities data reuse describes the distance between data creators and reusers across dimensions such as domain knowledge, methods, curation, purposes, collaboration, and time — all of which affect how easily a dataset can support a new question.

References for further reading:

Borgman, Christine L., and Paul Groth. “From Data Creator to Data Reuser: Distance Matters.” Harvard Data Science Review 7, no. 2 (2025). https://doi.org/10.1162/99608f92.35d32cfc .

Reusing Open Datasets

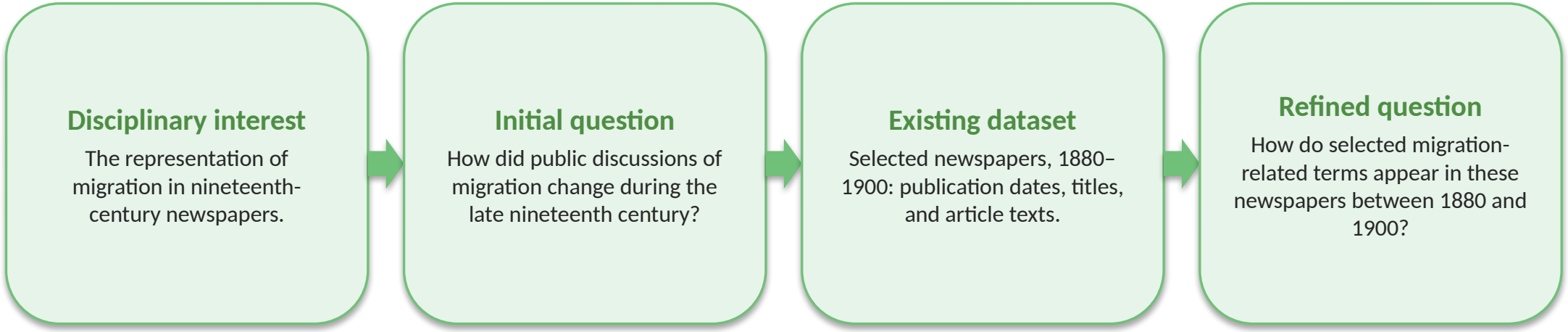
Open datasets create opportunities for new research questions, but reuse requires attention to the relation between the data's original purpose and the new project. When you reuse data, ask:

- What question shaped the original dataset?
- Which parts of the original purpose remain relevant?
- What new question do I want to explore?
- What information is available for that question?
- What context or additional sources do I need?

References for further reading:

Crane, Gregory, Alison Babeu, and James Tauber. "Humanities Data Reuse: Humanity First." Harvard Data Science Review 7, no. 2 (2025). https://hdsr.mitpress.mit.edu/pub/m0dqvamt.

An Example



The available data may support analysis of word frequency, distribution across newspapers, or change over time.

Additional historical research is required to interpret the social and political significance of the findings, because the original disciplinary interest remains important.

Humanities Data Requires Contextual Reading

- **Big, smart, clean and messy:** Schöch notes that humanities data can be extensive and well structured, yet also contain gaps, inconsistencies, ambiguous categories, and context-dependent meanings.
- **Interpretation matters:** Drucker stresses the interpretive character of data and visualisation — a chart shows a pattern, but the researcher interprets it through concepts, historical knowledge and source criticism, so choose visualisation types carefully.

Inspect the dataset before finalising the question. Ask:

- What does each record represent?
- Which fields or features are available?
- Who created the dataset, and what was its original purpose?
- What period, language, region or group does it cover?
- Which information is incomplete or uncertain?
- Which questions can the data support, and which have already been answered?

References for further reading:

Schöch, Christof. “Big? Smart? Clean? Messy? Data in the Humanities.” Journal of Digital Humanities 2, no. 3 (2013). https://journalofdigitalhumanities.org/2-3/big-smart-clean-messy-data-in-the-humanities/.

Drucker, Johanna. “Humanities Approaches to Graphical Display.” Digital Humanities Quarterly 5, no. 1 (2011). https://www.digitalhumanities.org/dhq/vol/5/1/000091/000091.html.

The Course Activity

- In this course, we use prepared open heritage data as a teaching resource.
- The practice environment guides you to formulate a simple question, inspect data, document decisions, and conduct a small analysis.
- You can begin with a general interest — in materials, dates, places, artists, institutions, objects, or other features.
- Then examine the dataset and formulate questions the fields and records can support with evidence.

References for further reading:

Booth, Wayne C., Gregory G. Colomb, and Joseph M. Williams. The Craft of Research. 2nd ed. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2003. See especially Chapter 3, “From Topics to Questions.”

Borgman, Christine L., and Paul Groth. “From Data Creator to Data Reuser: Distance Matters.” Harvard Data Science Review 7, no. 2 (2025). https://doi.org/10.1162/99608f92.35d32cfc.

Candela, Gustavo, María Dolores Sáez, M. Pilar Escobar Esteban, and Manuel Marco-Such. “Reusing Digital Collections from GLAM Institutions.” Journal of Information Science 48, no. 2 (2022): 251–67. https://doi.org/10.1177/0165551520950246.

Crane, Gregory, Alison Babeu, and James Tauber. “Humanities Data Reuse: Humanity First.” Harvard Data Science Review 7, no. 2 (2025). https://hdsr.mitpress.mit.edu/pub/m0dqvamt.

Drucker, Johanna. “Humanities Approaches to Graphical Display.” Digital Humanities Quarterly 5, no. 1 (2011). https://www.digitalhumanities.org/dhq/vol/5/1/000091/000091.html.

McGillivray, Barbara, Paola Marongiu, Nilo Pedrazzini, Marton Ribary, Mandy Wigdorowitz, and Eleonora Zordan. “Deep Impact: A Study on the Impact of Data Papers and Datasets in the Humanities and Social Sciences.” Publications 10, no. 4 (2022): 39. https://doi.org/10.3390/publications10040039.

Schöch, Christof. “Big? Smart? Clean? Messy? Data in the Humanities.” Journal of Digital Humanities 2, no. 3 (2013). https://journalofdigitalhumanities.org/2-3/big-smart-clean-messy-data-in-the-humanities/.